

"What strikes me most vividly about CRF is the remarkable pace of its evolution. In merely two years CRF has demonstrated that intellectual influence is not measured by age, but by relevance, rigour and the quality of its engagement with the issues of our time"

— Shashi Tharoor, Hon'ble MP

competitiveness and technology are no longer standalone issues. They are deeply interconnected and require collaboration across sectors and disciplines.

Speaking at the event, Mr Pranav Adani, Director, Adani Enterprises Limited (AEL), highlighted the importance of strengthening India's intellectual foundations alongside its economic ambitions. "As India's ambitions become larger, our challenges become more complex. Another form of infrastructure becomes equally important and that is intellectual infrastructure."

Adding to this perspective, Dr Shashi Tharoor, Member of Parliament and special invitee, emphasised that CRF has emerged at a pivotal moment when India requires institutions capable of thinking clearly about a world evolving at unprecedented speed, often faster than traditional frameworks can comprehend. He also highlighted the importance of integrating practical industry insights into policymaking, ensuring that decisions are neither shaped in an ideological vacuum nor driven by short-term considerations.

CRF's leadership reflects the institution's broader ambition. The Foundation is led by Mr Shishir Priyadarshi, a former Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer and former Director at the World Trade Organization (WTO), whose career has spanned public policy, international trade, multilateral institutions and development diplomacy. Explaining the thinking behind CRF, Mr Priyadarshi said, "The idea behind Chintan was to build a platform that is deeply Indian in perspective, globally engaged in outlook and practical in orientation."

Under his leadership, CRF has steadily expanded its engagement with universities, policy institutes, industry bodies and multilateral organisations across Asia, Africa, Europe and North America. These partnerships have helped bring global perspectives into Indian policy conversations while amplifying voices from developing economies in wider international debates.

Policy Impact

For any policy institution, influence is measured not only by the quality of its research, but also by its ability to shape conversations that contribute to public policy.

Over the past two years, CRF has published over 300 research pieces and convened over 80 dialogues, consultations and research-led engagements on issues ranging from trade and sustainability to gender, energy transition and the future of developing economies. More significantly, recommendations emerging from its work have led to wider discussions around the Shanti Bill 2025, provisions reflected in the Union Budget 2026, and policy deliberations concerning coal gasification, critical minerals and India's long-term energy security.

These developments underscore the growing role of research-driven institutions in helping governments, businesses and civil society navigate an increasingly complex policy environment.

The changing funding landscape has also contributed to this evolution. Alongside governments and international organisations, Indian industry and philanthropy are investing more actively in research and long-term institutional capacity. This has encouraged closer engagement between policymakers, businesses and researchers while creating new platforms for dialogue on national priorities.

Future Agenda

The significance of such institutions is likely to grow as India takes on a larger role in shaping global economic and strategic conversations.

In recent years, questions around climate resilience, energy transitions, digital governance, supply chains and sustainable development have become increasingly interconnected. Issues such as artificial intelligence, future trade architectures,



CRF's second Foundation Day in New Delhi on June 19 discussed the role of ideas in shaping India's future.



"The Foundation has consistently emphasised what it describes as the three Cs: collaboration, cooperation and collective action. The approach reflects a growing recognition that many contemporary challenges, whether climate change, supply-chain disruptions or technological transformation, cannot be addressed by governments, businesses or institutions acting alone."

— Mr Shishir Priyadarshi, President, CRF

gender, climate adaptation, energy security and industrial competitiveness will require sustained engagement across disciplines and sectors.

Addressing them requires institutions that can convene diverse stakeholders, encourage evidence-based debate and translate ideas into practical solutions.

CRF's second Foundation Day offered a glimpse into how the organisation intends to position itself within that landscape. The Foundation's ambitions extend beyond expanding its research portfolio. It seeks to deepen engagement on emerging policy challenges, strengthen dialogue between India and the wider developing world, and create platforms that bring together governments, industry leaders, multilateral institutions and civil society.

CRF increasingly serves as a bridge between research and action, creating opportunities for collaboration across sectors and geographies while ensuring that policy discussions remain grounded in real-world challenges.

Discussions during the event reflected the increasingly interconnected nature of policymaking, where economic growth, sustainability, technology and geopolitics are no longer separate conversations.

As India navigates an increasingly complex global landscape, institutions that can connect ideas with implementation will become ever more important. For CRF, the next challenge is not simply to shape conversations, but to help shape outcomes.